

BUILDING THE RIGHT PATH AHEAD



Anil Bhaskaran, the Bangalore based Architect and Urban Planner, believes that nature and history are our best teachers. 'Nature is the all-pervading soul of our planet. It imparts invaluable lessons on cohabitation, adaptation, survival and creativity. While our lives are shaped by how we experience nature, it still remains, by and large, an enigma. There is a lot to explore and learn from it,' he says.

Speaking about history he adds, 'History of architecture is a treasure-trove of information on how we have been responding to the facets of nature while building various types of shelters. History showcases the ingenious methods devised and used by our ancestors to tackle the challenges posed by nature.'

Bhaskaran obtained the Bachelor of Architecture Degree from the University of Kerala with the first rank and distinction. Subsequently, he completed the Master of Architecture Degree with a specialisation in Urban Planning, from the University of Minnesota, USA. Presently, he is the Managing Director, Chief Architect and Urban Planner of IDEA CENTRE, Bangalore.

He believes that many of the design features that were used in the past are of tremendous value even today. 'Take for example, the concept of a courtyard,' he says. 'In a traditional building, besides performing the role of a large sized hot air-vent, an open-to-sky internal courtyard was

also its 'soul space' that established a direct link between the building and cosmos'.

He continues, 'Another example is the use of jalis in the historical buildings. They were something in between an opaque wall and an open window. Usually installed on the edges of the verandas abutting the exterior walls, the

jalis allowed the controlled passage of air into and out of the buildings, thereby allowing the buildings to 'breathe' easily. They also facilitated the entry of diffused light into the buildings, keeping the rooms optimally lit.'

It is no coincidence then that courtyards and jalis have found their rightful place in many of his buildings, including the recently completed Novitiate in Bangalore.

Being a lover of art and an artist himself, he tries to incorporate art, especially abstract art in his buildings. 'I see buildings as an expression of art. Apart from being a decorative element, art has the wonderful ability to make a space look more joyful. Traditional Indian buildings, especially the temples and palaces, usually had elaborate works of art in the form of motives and paintings on their walls and ceilings. In some cases, like the gopurams of Meenakshi temple in Madurai or Kajariho temple, the buildings themselves give the appearance of giant sculptures'.

The idea of buildings as three dimensional art...more precisely... sculptures, finds its place in his projects such as Jal Bhavan and St Euphrasia's Pre-University College in Bangalore, that derive their overall forms from abstract art.

He believes that our buildings and cities need to be in harmony with nature. Unsurprisingly, the hundred acre university campus in Andhra Pradesh and a premium resort in Raipur, two of his new projects, incorporate a wide range of eco-friendly features.

A recipient of many awards and honours, Bhaskaran's passion in architecture extends into urban planning too, which has led him to researching and developing many new theories in city planning, over the last decade.



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